to resolve the entire boundary issue? Obviously, no. Strong enough to also resolve legacy issues? Unlikely, as we ourselves had started with the premise of status quo of April 2020. PP-15 and PP-17? Perhaps yes. But in my opinion, this was a case of '*haathi nikal gaya, dum rahe gayi*'. The major part had been achieved and we should go with that. The PLA proposal had started with only going back to Finger 5; then back to Finger 8, but retaining fifty personnel at Finger 5; then going back beyond Finger 8 but reserving the right to patrol up to Finger 5. We had stuck to our guns and reached this stage. In trying for that last 20 per cent, we should not lose the more important 80 per cent. Ultimately, we agreed to go ahead with the proposal in its current form with the proviso that this was only a precursor to complete disengagement. This was acceptable to the Chinese side also.

The disengagement process was complex. North Bank (Step 1, Step 2, Step 3); South Bank (Step 1, Step 2, Step 3); Kailash Range (Step 1, Step 2, Step 3). These steps were to be undertaken in sequence starting with the disengagement of armour, then all the Step 1s, Step 2s and finally, the Step 3s, starting each time from the North Bank. It was a sight to behold when the tanks started up, spewing dark black smoke in the pristine air, turned their turrets towards us (which had been facing rearwards as a confidence-building measure), dipped their guns in farewell and trundled off from where they had come almost six months earlier. By evening, they had gone over 50 km to the rear as agreed to, paving the way for the other Steps. The disengagement was no less spectacular. The images of PLA troops dismantling their sangars, razing them to the ground and moving back to their garrisons in the rear were flashed on TV screens worldwide. It was the first time ever, that not only had the Chinese withdrawn but also removed their infrastructure. The disengagement, which

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